
SESSION 4D

HABITS TO FORM: PRAYING LIKE JESUS

For our “Habits to Form” section, we will focus on prayer, and specifically, the most excellent prayer in the Bible: the one Jesus taught us to pray. It is a comprehensive prayer that can be the template for a lifetime of growth in prayer.

MATTHEW 6:9-13 (ESV)

⁹ Pray then like this:

“Our Father in heaven,
hallowed be your name.
¹⁰ Your kingdom come,
your will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
¹¹ Give us this day our daily bread,
¹² and forgive us our debts,
as we also have forgiven our debtors.
¹³ And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.

One thing to notice is that all the first person pronouns are plural.

Our Father in heaven,
Hallowed be your name.
Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.
Give **us** this day **our** daily bread,
And forgive **us our** debts, as **we** also have forgiven **our** debtors.
And lead **us** not into temptation, but deliver **us** from evil.

We are not taught to pray, “My Father” but “Our Father.” This is a powerful reminder that once we claim God as our Father, we receive many brothers and sisters. We are not to live this life alone, but with others who call God “Father.”

OUR FATHER

As we learn to pray the Lord’s Prayer, we can pray it as given in the text, or we can pause to explore and expand on each phrase. The truths contained in these phrases are worth dwelling on until they become permanently etched into our hearts.

The first words are “our Father.”

What does it mean that God is our Father?

Look at the examples below for some ideas on how you can expand or dwell on this truth.

“Our Father”

Prayer Example #1

Father, I acknowledge that you are my heavenly father. You are the one who is responsible for my life. Without you, I would not be. Yet, I live as if I am an orphan in this universe. God, I want to affirm the truth that you are my father and that I am not alone. I want to live out the truth that I have a Father who loves me, who is the powerful, eternal God of the universe by being secure, courageous, calm and assured of who I am as a child of God.”

Prayer Example #2

God, you are my Father, but because I didn't have a dad growing up I thought I had to fend for myself and I needed to ensure security for myself. But because you are my Heavenly Father and you are always there for me, I can now rest from fear of lack and this sense that the world is a hostile place. I can now worry less about getting ahead, or accumulating wealth, but be generous to others.

OUR FATHER IN HEAVEN

God is "Our Father in heaven." If we have a father, and He is in heaven, where is our home? Home is where our heavenly father is. Therefore, this world is not our true home; heaven is our eternal home. One of the most significant shifts that we make as we become a follower of Jesus is from being earth-bound to heaven-bound. Our hearts, therefore, need to be weaned from the things of the world as we long for heaven, our eternal permanent home.

Prayer Example:

God, my eternal home is in heaven and not on earth...

I thank you that through the salvation I have received from Christ Jesus, my new identity and my permanent status and position is that of God's beloved and a citizen of God's kingdom. Help me daily claim my identity as a sojourner passing through this world. God, I want to be wise each day investing in things that will last in Heaven. Please give me opportunities to do so today.

HALLOWED BE YOUR NAME

"Hallowed" means to honor as holy. This means that God's name and who He is should be treated separate, different and with the highest regard. No other name deserves this reverence.

And to pray for God's name to be regarded as holy implies two things on our part:

- (1) We will labor to make it so.
- (2) We will have no idols—no one or nothing should be above God in our hearts.

Prayer Example:

Lord, my prayer is that your name be honored...

I praise you for you are transcendent, holy and perfect. You are the only one deserving of such honor and reverence. I recognize that your name has been profaned in our fallen world and want to change that by committing to living a life that honors you and lifts up your name.

I pledge to never bow down to any idol, idols of power, prestige, pleasure. You alone deserve the highest regard in all that I do.

YOUR KINGDOM, COME, YOUR WILL BE DONE, ON EARTH AS IT IS IN HEAVEN

This means that God's kingdom hasn't fully come. His kingdom is yet to come. And we are to pray that this will happen. God's rule, while always done in heaven, is not always done on earth. His will is actually resisted on earth.

We are to extend the kingdom of God. This starts in each of our hearts, of course, when we dethrone ourselves, and allow his rule and will to be done in us. But it goes further than that: we are to pray this prayer. We are to labor in prayer for the gospel to be proclaimed, for lost people to be found, and for sinners to repent.

Prayer Example:

Lord, my prayer is that your will be done and that it will be done through my life. I'm sorry for the ways in which I have pursued my own kingdom and my own will on this earth by succumbing to desire for emotional comfort. ...

Lord, I pray that your will be done on our campus; that your rightful rule will be recognized in our family ...

GIVE US THIS DAY OUR DAILY BREAD

Our Father in heaven,
Hallowed be your name.
Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
And forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil.

The last three petitions of the Lord's Prayer have to do with our needs. Daily bread represents our fundamental biological need—things we need for our physical survival. In this petition, we own up to the fact of our physical frailty, and bring our needs before our Father. God knows that these trivialities and small matters occupy our lives. He knows we can't live on empty stomachs. If we can't speak to God about this, we would feel fatherless. Without this prayer, we would be forced to relate to God only in "spiritual" matters, while fending for our own bread.

God wants us to bring to Him our needs from every area of our lives. There isn't a need that is too practical or too trivial for God to care about. This is because He knows us; He knows that it is the little desires, the little hungers, the thousand worries, anxieties, pains and small necessities of life that can defeat us. We are thus able to approach God confidently with all our needs knowing that he welcomes us.

FORGIVE US OUR DEBTS, AS WE ALSO HAVE FORGIVEN OUR DEBTORS

Forgiveness of sins is essential for spiritual life. Not only in our salvation, but also as a daily act of truth-telling before God, and in relating with him in the closeness of an open and honest relationship.

The truth that we have been completely forgiven is not a static truth, but it works itself outward towards others. Because we ourselves have been forgiven, we are enabled to forgive others. We can be generous with others, knowing we all have the same problem of sin.

AND LEAD US NOT INTO TEMPTATION, BUT DELIVER US FROM EVIL

We need to be consistently and keenly aware of the spiritual warfare we are in, where Satan is at work and looking for an opportunity to tempt us. In this prayer, we are humbly acknowledging our frailty against temptation and evil, but also confidently claiming God's power to deliver us in the hour of temptation and protect us from evil.

PERSONALIZING THE LORD'S PRAYER

Now, following the phrases of the Lord's Prayer, please write out your personalized, expanded prayer in the table below.

Our Father	God, you are my Father...
In heaven	God, my eternal home is in heaven and not on earth...
Hallowed be your name	Lord, my prayer is that your name be honored...
Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven	Lord, my prayer is that your will be done...
Give us this day our daily bread	

And forgive us our debts	
As we also have forgiven our debtors	
And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil	